

The Arctic

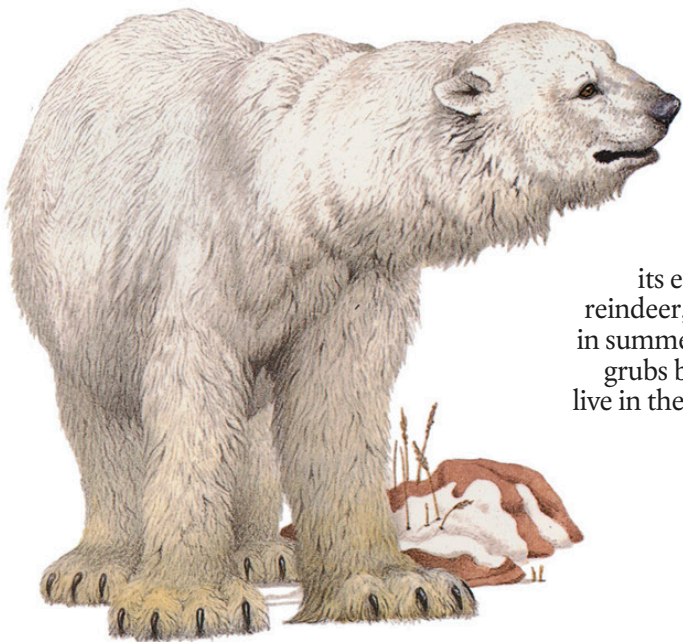


THE ARCTIC consists of the northernmost parts of North America, Europe, and Asia, which is tundra (frozen land), and a huge area of frozen ocean around the North Pole. It is one of the coldest places on Earth. The temperature rarely rises above 50°F (10°C), and in the winter it often drops to -40°F (-40°C). During the brief summer period, it is light for 24 hours a day. Light and warmth encourage the growth of tiny sea animals and plants called plankton, which are eaten by fish, seals, and birds. On land, flowers bloom, providing food for millions of insects. Many birds migrate to the Arctic to breed and raise their young. When the winter sets in again, these birds return to warmer climates.

Polar bear

(*Ursus maritimus*)

Height at shoulder: up to 4 ft 11 in (1.5 m)
Body length: up to 9 ft 7 in (2.9 m)



Lethal paws

The polar bear is a huge animal and can weigh as much as 10 adult people. It feeds mainly on seals, and often catches them at holes in the ice when they come up for air. One swipe from the bear's massive paws can kill a seal, and its claws then grab and hold onto its prey.

Longest hair

The musk ox has the longest coat of almost any mammal. Some hairs in its outer coat are nearly 3 ft 3 in (1 m) long. If a group of musk oxen are attacked, they form a tight circle and defend themselves with their sharp horns, while the young stand in the middle for protection.



Food store

During the summer the Arctic fox stores food, such as dead birds, under rocks. Thanks to the cold climate, this food keeps as well as it would in a refrigerator. The fox eats it in the winter months, when fresh food is hard to find. The fox's thick fur coat helps it survive in temperatures as low as -58°F (-50°C).



Arctic fox

(*Alopex lagopus*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 5 in (75 cm)
Tail: up to 16.7 in (42.5 cm)

Wonderful whiskers

The bearded seal lives in the seas around the edge of the ice cap. It has long, sensitive whiskers, which it uses to feel for shellfish on the sea bed. In spring, the female hauls herself onto the ice to give birth.



Bearded seal

(*Erignathus barbatus*)

Length: up to 8 ft 2 in (2.5 m)



Reindeer warble-fly

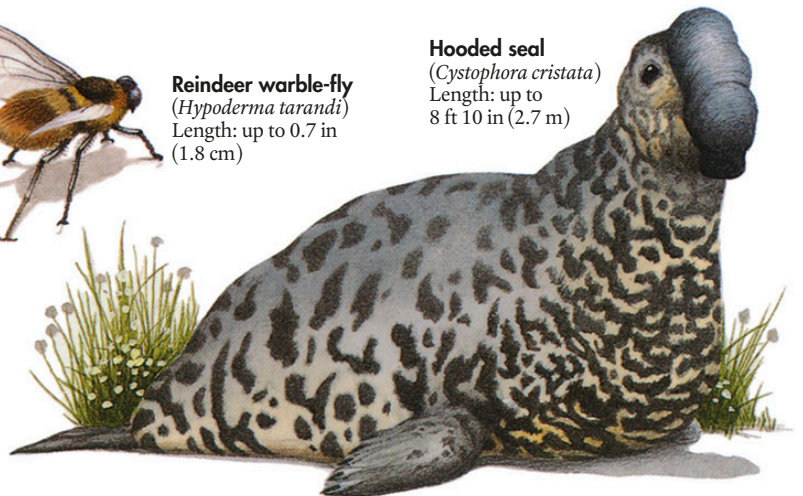
(*Hypoderma tarandi*)
Length: up to 0.7 in (1.8 cm)

Fearsome fly
The reindeer warble-fly lays its eggs in the fur of caribou and reindeer, which migrate to the Arctic in summer. When the eggs hatch, the grubs burrow through the skin and live in the deer's flesh. The grubs later fall off and grow into adults.

Hooded seal

(*Cystophora cristata*)

Length: up to 8 ft 10 in (2.7 m)



Balloon nose

The male hooded seal has a strange balloonlike structure on the end of his nose. In the breeding season, he blows air into this structure, which can become 12 in (30 cm) long. The air amplifies the loud calls he makes to warn off other males. The hooded seal spends most of its life at sea, searching for fish and squid. It only comes out onto the ice to mate, breed, and molt.

Musk ox

(*Ovibos moschatus*)

Height at shoulder: up to 5 ft (1.5 m)

Narwhal

(*Monodon monoceros*)

Body length: up to 16 ft 9 in (5 m)
Tusk: up to 9 ft 10 in (3 m)



Arctic unicorn

The narwhal is a mammal related to whales and dolphins. It has only two teeth. One of the male's teeth grows into a long, spiraling tusk, which sticks out through a hole in his top lip. The tusks are used to display dominance, and males have been seen fighting one another with their tusks.